

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a newspaper:

Gardening becomes a way of healing

Horticultural therapy is a professional practice that uses plants and gardening to improve mental and physical health. A horticultural therapist works with any group that can benefit from interaction with plants, including children, the elderly and those dealing with addiction and mental health problems.

"I was suffering from depression, which seriously affected my life," Mary Wright, a patient at a mental health centre, said. "One day, I was asked, 'Can you do flower arranging? Can you water and take care of plants?' I said, 'Well, I'll try it.'"

"It was exactly the help I needed," she said. "When I'm touching a plant, it's a very calming experience. It helped me get better."

Many studies have found that just being in nature – such as taking a walk through a garden, a park or a forest – can improve not only your state of mind but your blood pressure, your heart rate and your stress levels and, over time, can lead to a longer life.

Studies have also found that horticultural therapy supports recovery and improves mood, resulting in shorter stays for patients at hospitals and mental health facilities.



Horticultural therapy, or gardening, as a way of healing, can benefit many people.

Your school wants to develop students' interest in growing plants. Your class teacher wants you to discuss this idea. You may want to talk about:

- what benefits growing plants can bring to students and the school
- whether growing plants will be popular among students
- what other activities can help promote students' well-being
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like going to country parks?
2. Do you like gardening?
3. Do more young people or older people enjoy caring for plants?
4. Are there enough green spaces in Hong Kong?
5. Is gardening a popular hobby in Hong Kong?
6. Do you prefer caring for plants or keeping a pet?
7. Should there be plants in the work environment?
8. Which do you prefer: real or artificial plants?